

9.4

Tentative language

Worksheet

- A** Practise each pair of sentences. Say the sentences on the left in a strong, clear, direct way. Say the sentences on the right in a tentative, careful, thoughtful way: speak more slowly and use pauses.

- | | |
|--------------------------------------|--|
| 1 Our competitors are expensive. | <u>I'm afraid</u> our competitors <u>aren't very cheap</u> . |
| 2 There's a problem with that. | <u>I think</u> there's <u>a bit of a problem</u> with that. |
| 3 It'll be better use Air Express. | Wouldn't it be better to use Air Express? |
| 4 We can't do that. | To be honest, I'm not sure we could do that. |
| 5 There's a misunderstanding. | There seems to be a slight misunderstanding. |
| 6 That's going to be difficult. | I guess that could be a little difficult. |
| 7 That gives us very little time. | Actually, that doesn't give us very much time. |
| 8 The transport costs are expensive. | The transport costs are a bit expensive, aren't they? |

Underline all the words in the second column that make the language tentative. The first two have been done for you.

- B** Complete the table below with the sentence numbers from section A. The first two have been done for you.

a could/would

2
1

b I think / I guess

c phrase to introduce bad news

d negative question

e is → seems to be

f a little / a bit (+ adjective)

g a slight / a bit of a (+ noun)

h not (+ opposite)

2
1

- What do you think about this example? *I'm afraid there seems to be a slight problem.*

- C** Rewrite this dialogue so that it is more tentative. Use techniques from section B and your own ideas.

Customer

- Product X is very expensive.
- If we buy product X, what terms will you give us?
- Can we have more credit?
- We have a problem with our cash-flow.
- OK.

Supplier

- It's more expensive than product Y, but it's much better.
- What do you mean?
- That will be difficult. You're over your limit.
- Pay some of the money you owe us.
- In that case we'll be more flexible.

Start like this:

- To be honest, product X seems a bit expensive.
- It's a little more expensive than product Y, but the quality is better.
- ...

- D** Discuss:

- In what situations would you expect to hear tentative language?
- Do you use tentative structures in your own language?

